TEACHER COPY · VERSION A · the key is in bold, with why under each answer

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version A

Grade 7 · English / Reading · Making inferences and citing text evidence (fiction and nonfiction)

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. Fill in the circle next to the best answer.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. In paragraph 1, how does Kiran feel about his four days with Biscuit?

L1 · infer a character's feelings or beliefs

A. nervous that Biscuit will not like him

B. sorry he agreed to watch someone else's cat

C. set on proving he can take care of a pet

D. sure the job will be easy and quick

Answer: **C. set on proving he can take care of a pet**

Why: The four days "felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score" [1], after three years of asking for a pet. He shows no worry yet that Biscuit won't like him (that comes on Monday and Tuesday [3]-[4]); nothing shows he is sorry; he plans to work hard and never calls the job easy.

2. In paragraph 5, why doesn't Kiran call Biscuit on Wednesday evening?

L2 · infer why a character acts

A. His mind is on the math test he has to study for.

B. He plans to ignore her so she will come to him.

C. Mrs. Abara's notes told him to leave her alone.

D. He has given up on ever winning Biscuit over.

Answer: **A. His mind is on the math test he has to study for.**

Why: He has "a math test to study for and no energy for singing" and "forgot to call her" [5]. It is not a plan: he forgot. Mrs. Abara says Biscuit is shy [1], and the written note is about Dev's Thursday visit; nothing tells him to leave her alone. He has not given up: he forgot to call her, and on Thursday he asks to come back [7].

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3. Part A: Near the end of the story, why does Kiran stop in the middle of a sentence?

L3 · infer what a character realizes

A. He remembers he was told not to take Biscuit's shyness personally.

B. He sees Biscuit watching him and does not want to upset her.

C. He sees that Biscuit must have eaten the food herself.

D. He does not want to blame Dev for the food in front of him.

Answer: **C. He sees that Biscuit must have eaten the food herself.**

Why: Two steps: on Monday Kiran said Dev "must have come by and tossed it out" [3], but the note says Dev comes Thursday [1], and Dev is only now there [7]. Seeing Dev, Kiran sees nobody threw the food out, so Biscuit ate it. He was told not to take her shyness personally [1], but his half-sentence is about the food ("She didn't eat at first" [7]), not her shyness; Biscuit is calm on the armchair [7], and he looks at Dev, not at her, when he stops; Dev could not have tossed the food on Monday, so there is nothing to blame him for.

4. Part B: Which quotation from the story BEST supports the answer to Part A?

L2 · choose the best supporting quotation

A. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," [1]

B. "Dev will come Thursday to water the plants." [1]

C. "On Monday, Dev's watering can sat by the empty bowl." [3]

D. "Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him." [7]

Answer: **B. "Dev will come Thursday to water the plants." [1]**

Why: Key: the note shows Dev was not coming until Thursday [1], so he could not have tossed the food on Monday, and Biscuit ate it. The shy line [1] backs "told not to take her shyness personally"; the armchair line [7] backs "does not want to upset her." "On Monday, Dev's watering can sat by the empty bowl" is unmatched (backs "blame Dev"): the passage contradicts it, since Dev comes Thursday [1] and Kiran only guesses "Dev must have come by"; the real line in [3] is "That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair."

5. On Tuesday, what does Kiran try, and how does Biscuit respond? Quote the sentence that shows how she responds and give its paragraph number. L2 · cite evidence for a claim

Answer: **He waves a feather toy and sings; she looks at him and then moves away: "Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away." [4]**

Why: Full credit: the toy or the singing, her watching and then slipping away, and the [4] sentence. "She hides" or "she ignores him" with no line from [4] earns at most half credit.

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The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds once grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

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Questions 6-12: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, when did the first drells move onto the platforms?

L1 · find a detail in the text

A. the same summer the platforms were built

B. five summers after the platforms were built

C. in 1980, once the reeds stood again

D. the spring after the platforms were built

Answer: **D. the spring after the platforms were built**

Why: The platforms were built in 1971, and "Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring" [5]. Five summers is how long the shoots kept vanishing [6]; 1980 is when every platform was in use [6]; nothing says drells moved in the summer of building.

7. Why did the drells most likely stay away from the North Lagoon for years after the storm?

L2 · infer a cause the text does not spell out

A. The fishermen kept chasing them away.

B. Too few thick reeds were left for nesting.

C. Salt from the storm had killed the snails they ate.

D. There was too little food left for them to eat.

Answer: **B. Too few thick reeds were left for nesting.**

Why: Drells nest only in thick reeds [1]; the storm flattened the North's reeds [2], the new shoots were gone each summer [3], and only the last reed clumps were left [5]. Drells came back once platforms were hidden in those clumps [5]. No one chased them (they flew off with nowhere to nest [2]); the kibs crowded the mud [4], so they were not killed; food was not short, since the mud was crowded with kibs [4], which drells eat [1].

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8. Based on the article, why did the North Lagoon's reeds stay away after 1961, when they had come back after smaller storms? L3 · trace a cause-and-effect chain

A. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.

B. This storm left salt in the water that never washed out.

C. This storm buried the roots under sand from the dunes.

D. This storm drove off the fish that ate the snails.

Answer: **A. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.**
Why: Two steps: after 1961 the drells flew off [2]; without drells almost nothing ate the kibs, and the kibs ate the new shoots [4]; so shoots that came up each spring were gone each summer [3]. Selk found the water no saltier than the South's [4]; shoots came up every spring [3], so the roots were not buried; no fish are said to eat snails, and without drells "almost nothing was eating the kibs" [4].

9. Part A: Why does the author tell about the islanders planting reeds by hand?
L3 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. to show that new plants could not last while the snails went uneaten

B. to show that salt left by the storm still killed young plants

C. to show that planting by hand worked for a while

D. to show that the islanders did not want the drells back

Answer: **A. to show that new plants could not last while the snails went uneaten**
Why: Two steps: the hand-planted reeds were eaten too [5], and without drells almost nothing ate the kibs [4]; so planting could not work until something ate the snails, which is why the platforms came next [5]. Selk found the water no saltier than the South's [4]; the planted reeds were eaten, not standing [5]; nothing says the islanders as a whole wanted the drells gone (only some fishermen were glad [2]), and they built platforms to bring them back [5].

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10. Part B: Which quotation from the article BEST supports the answer to Part A? L2 · choose the best supporting quotation

A. "Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in." [3]

B. "By summer the planted reeds stood tall along the shore." [5]

C. "Some fishermen were glad." [2]

D. "The snails ate those too." [5]

Answer: **D. "The snails ate those too." [5]**

Why: Key: the planted reeds were eaten by the snails [5], so new plants could not last while the snails went uneaten. The salt line [3] backs "salt left by the storm still killed young plants"; "Some fishermen were glad" [2] backs "the islanders did not want the drells back." "By summer the planted reeds stood tall along the shore" is unmatched (backs "planting by hand worked for a while"): the passage contradicts it; the real line in [5] is "The snails ate those too," and shoots kept vanishing for five summers [6].

11. Why does the author say Selk went out after dark? L2 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. to show she was searching for the drells that had left

B. to show the shoots were being eaten at night

C. to show that her water test had to be done at night

D. to show she did not want the fishermen to see her

Answer: **B. to show the shoots were being eaten at night**

Why: After dark, with a lamp, Selk saw the mud crowded with kib snails eating the new shoots down to the roots [4]; drells also feed at night [1]. Nothing says she was looking for drells; she tested the water before going out [4]; the fishermen are not in [4], and nothing says she hid from anyone.

12. What does "thinner" mean as it is used in paragraph 6? Quote a sentence from an earlier paragraph that helps show the meaning, and give its paragraph number. L2 · word meaning from context, with evidence

Answer: **Fewer and more spread out, not crowded: "The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots." [4]**

Why: Full credit: a meaning like "fewer / less crowded" plus the [4] sentence about the crowded mud. "Skinnier" is the everyday sense and does not fit. A meaning with no line from the passage earns at most half credit.

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CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

13. How does Kiran change from the beginning of "Biscuit" to the end? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer. L3 · infer how a character changes (RACE)

> A strong answer: **Kiran changes from trying hard and loudly to win Biscuit over to being calm and patient. At first he calls and taps the bowl "louder each time" [2]. Later he "did not reach for her" [6], and he asks to come back [7].**
>
> Why: Score with the RACE CHECKLIST. Strong evidence: [2] or [4] for the start; [5], [6] or [7] for the end. The Explain row needs how each quote shows the change.

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Skills and level map

Each question's skill and level (1 = on-ramp, 2 = on level, 3 = harder, often two steps). Version A and B test the same skill at the same level, question for question.

Level 1: 2 (15%)	**Level 2**: 7 (54%)	**Level 3**: 4 (31%)

Skill	Questions	How many
infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	1
infer why a character acts	2	1
infer what a character realizes	3	1
choose the best supporting quotation	4, 10	2
cite evidence for a claim	5	1
find a detail in the text	6	1
infer a cause the text does not spell out	7	1
trace a cause-and-effect chain	8	1
infer why the author includes a detail	9, 11	2
word meaning from context, with evidence	12	1
infer how a character changes (RACE)	13	1

#	Skill	Level	Type	Key (version A)
1	infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	mc	**C. set on proving he can take care of a pet**
2	infer why a character acts	2	mc	**A. His mind is on the math test he has to study for.**
3	infer what a character realizes	3	mc	**C. He sees that Biscuit must have eaten the food herself.**
4	choose the best supporting quotation	2	mc	**B. "Dev will come Thursday to water the plants." [1]**
5	cite evidence for a claim	2	short	**He waves a feather toy and sings; she looks at him and then moves away: "Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away." [4]**
6	find a detail in the text	1	mc	**D. the spring after the platforms were built**

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7	infer a cause the text does not spell out	2	mc	**B. Too few thick reeds were left for nesting.**
8	trace a cause-and-effect chain	3	mc	**A. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.**
9	infer why the author includes a detail	3	mc	**A. to show that new plants could not last while the snails went uneaten**
10	choose the best supporting quotation	2	mc	**D. "The snails ate those too." [5]**
11	infer why the author includes a detail	2	mc	**B. to show the shoots were being eaten at night**
12	word meaning from context, with evidence	2	short	**Fewer and more spread out, not crowded: "The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots." [4]**
13	infer how a character changes (RACE)	3	open	**Kiran changes from trying hard and loudly to win Biscuit over to being calm and patient. At first he calls and taps the bowl "louder each time" [2]. Later he "did not reach for her" [6], and he asks to come back [7].**

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